votary of orthodox Brahminism and Advaita Vedanta, who also set up monastic educational institutions, or *matha*s, to rival Buddhist monasteries. He advocated the worship of Vishnu, Shiva, Shakti, Ganesh and Surya as 'different forms of the one *Brahman*, the invisible Supreme Being', deftly appropriating and uniting Puranic cults under Brahminism.[23] Other major new social forces included Bhakti, a mystical devotional movement, and various folk and Tantric cults whose origins mostly lay outside the Vedic–Brahminic fold. Buddhism's decline, writes Thapar, 'is partly linked to the popularity of religious devotionalism' and 'a variety of sects, such as the Tantric and Shakta'.

Many historians see this new religious profusion—of folk and Puranic deities, syncretic beliefs and devotionalism, yogic sexual practices and imagery of Tantra—as marking a shift from Brahminism to a new entity called Hinduism (a colonial-era label, retroactively applied).[24] This early Hinduism was fervent and unorthodox, and capacious enough to embrace many popular features of Buddhism—such as monastic orders, vegetarianism, prohibition of animal sacrifices, some resistance to caste—and even appropriated the Buddha as the ninth avatar of Vishnu.

One could say that the religious market was shifting to more user-friendly products in which Buddhism began losing lay followers, owing to its relatively sober and austere practices and the alienating monastic–scholastic focus of its priestly class. The popular new Hindu sects, cults and devotional movements combined so much fusion and appropriation of practices that it may not have seemed like a big shift to lay Buddhists. From Yijing's account, even their rituals were quite similar, and likely became more so. Dharmasvamin (1197–1264), a Tibetan monk pilgrim to Nalanda, saw both Hindus and Buddhists bathe their deities in curd, milk, honey, sugar and ghee. The real but complex theological and philosophical differences perhaps didn't matter much to lay Buddhists. Over multiple generations, they began to flock to specialized Hindu gods that were seen as responding to their mundane woes and misfortunes and presiding over their rites of passage. With this shift among the populace, the royal patronage for Buddhism began drying up too.

Some scholars also blame the lavish land endowments that Nalanda and other monasteries had accrued since the Guptas, including tax revenues in